



SYS 478 003
Senior-Year Seminar
Fall 2026

Course Information

Room Location: RRO 217

Day(s) and Time(s): 3:15 PM-4:55 PM TR

Modality: Face-to-Face

Catalog Description and Prerequisites

In the Senior-Year Seminar, SYS 478, students assume the role of global citizens to address an issue or a group of related issues of current and future importance to the world at large. Students will be expected to integrate the knowledge they have acquired through their major with the broader perspectives provided in their core curriculum courses. As such, the Senior-Year Seminar is intended to be taken in the final year. SYS 478 is a topical course taught by faculty from all disciplines. While issues covered by individual sections will vary based on faculty expertise, all sections of SYS 478 intend to raise students' cognizance of their place in the world and the responsibilities of global citizenry. May not be used to fulfill major or minor requirements. May not be used to fulfill other requirements within the core curriculum. Students may receive credit for only one section of SYS 478. Senior Standing required and must be taken in residency.

Student Learning Outcomes

- Analyze AI as a socio-technical system, examining how technical systems are shaped by human choices, institutions, values, infrastructure, and

material conditions.

- Apply ethical and governance frameworks to emerging AI technologies, considering affected stakeholders, possible futures, alternatives, safeguards, and opportunities for intervention.
- Communicate technical, social, and ethical dimensions of AI clearly to non-specialist audiences through discussion, writing, visual communication, and public-facing work.
- Develop a high-level understanding of selected technical concepts that help explain how contemporary AI systems work and why their design matters.
- Develop professional goals and communication practices that connect students' academic experience, interests, and skills to future professional or educational opportunities.
- Evaluate the social and ethical implications of AI design and deployment, including questions of power, bias, surveillance, labor, accountability, explainability, environmental impact, and distribution of benefits and harms.
- Identify and critically examine the judgments embedded in AI systems, including choices about categories, measurement, datasets, proxies, baselines, predictions, and acceptable error.

Required Materials Purchase

None. There are no required textbooks or other materials that students must purchase for this course.

Other Required Materials

Required readings and other course materials, including articles, reports, videos, and other media, will be provided or linked through the course website. No additional purchase is required.

Diversity of Intellectual Perspectives

University and college courses engage diverse scholarly perspectives to develop critical thinking, analysis, and debate. Inclusion of a reading does not imply endorsement. Syllabi do not constitute an express or implied contract among the student, faculty, or institution. Rather, syllabi serve as a guide for courses. Syllabi are directed works that are developed within the scope of an instructor's

employment and under institutional direction. The institution is considered the copyright owner of course syllabi, as directed work. As such, syllabi shall be treated as “public records.” Publicly available syllabi are not required to include the location or time of day at which a course is being held. No syllabus shall include any personally identifiable information of students (e.g. race, gender, ethnicity, etc.

Grading Scale

Letter Grade	Percentage Range
A	93–100%
A-	90–92.9%
B+	87–89.9%
B	83–86.9%
B-	80–82.9%
C+	77–79.9%
C	73–76.9%
C-	70–72.9%
D+	67–69.9%
D	60–66.9%
F	<60%

Grading Components

Assignment	Percentage of Grade
Reading Preparation & Responses	15%
Homework & Labs	35%
Professional Development Activities	25%
Applied AI & Society Final Project	25%

Final Exam Information

Students will present their final projects during the course’s scheduled final exam period.

Attendance Policy

Regular attendance is a required part of this course. This is a discussion-based class, and much of our learning will happen through conversation: asking questions, working through difficult ideas, connecting concepts across readings and cases, and making sense of the material together. Missing class therefore means missing an important part of the learning that cannot always be recreated through readings or assignments alone.

You may miss up to three class meetings without a grade penalty. You do not need to provide documentation or an explanation for these absences; they are intended to provide flexibility for illness, emergencies, appointments, and other circumstances that may arise during the semester.

Beginning with the fourth absence, each additional missed class meeting will lower your final course grade by one half-letter grade step:

- 4 absences: A → A-
- 5 absences: A → B+
- 6 absences: A → B
- 7 absences: A → B-
- and so on.

The attendance penalty is applied after your final numerical course grade has been calculated from course assignments and activities.

Absences covered by an approved university accommodation or other applicable university policy will be handled in accordance with that policy. If circumstances arise that are likely to result in an extended absence, please contact me as soon as you reasonably can so that we can determine how they affect your ability to complete the course.

Participation Policy

This course depends on active participation and collective sense-making. Many of the ideas we will encounter are complex, contested, or unfamiliar, and we will use

class discussion to work through them together. You are expected to come to class having engaged with the assigned materials and prepared to contribute to our work as a learning community.

Attendance alone does not constitute participation. Meaningful participation can take many forms and does not require being the person who speaks most often. This means:

- Coming to class prepared, having completed the assigned readings or other materials.
- Bringing questions, observations, connections, or points of confusion to our discussions.
- Contributing thoughtfully to whole-class discussions, small-group activities, and other course work.
- Listening carefully to others and seeking to understand perspectives different from your own.
- Building on, questioning, or complicating one another's ideas in ways that help the group think more deeply.
- Making space for others to contribute as well as contributing yourself.
- Giving classmates the benefit of the doubt about their competence and intentions, and expecting the same in return.
- Helping create a learning environment characterized by curiosity, respect, professionalism, and consideration for others.

Participation does not require having a fully formed opinion or arriving at the "right" answer. Asking a useful question, working through uncertainty, making a connection, identifying a tension, changing your mind, or helping the group clarify an idea are all meaningful contributions.

Disagreement, questions, mistakes, and differing perspectives are welcome. Disrespectful, disruptive, or unethical behavior is not.

Academic Integrity Policy

The university's policy on academic honesty states that "As a community of scholars dedicated to learning and the pursuit of knowledge UNC Asheville relies on the honesty and academic integrity of all the members of its community. Any act of plagiarism or cheating is academic dishonesty. A person who knowingly assists another in cheating is likewise guilty of cheating. According to the instructor's view of the gravity of the offense, a student may be punished by a

failing grade or a grade of zero for the assignment or test, or a failing grade in the course. If it seems warranted, the instructor may also recommend to the Provost dismissal or other serious university sanction." I expect that you will exercise integrity in all quizzes, exams, and written assignments. Please email me or come see me during office hours if you have additional questions or need clarification on any point.

Office of Accessibility & Academic Accommodations

UNC Asheville is committed to providing accessible learning environments and equal opportunity to individuals with disabilities in accordance with the [Americans with Disabilities Act \(ADA\)](#) and [Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act](#).

If you are a student experiencing barriers to access or full participation in this course on the basis of a disability, contact the Office of Accessibility (OA) to apply for reasonable accommodations and discuss available resources. You may contact the OA at accessibility@unca.edu or 828-251-6292 or visit Zageir Hall Room 120/121.

To discuss approved academic accommodations, please contact me as early in the semester as possible and provide your letter of accommodation (LOA) from the OA. I want to ensure that we have adequate time and a confidential setting to discuss and arrange your approved accommodations. Accommodations are not retroactive and will be implemented when the LOA is discussed.

Academic Alerts

As part of UNC Asheville's student success efforts, faculty have access to an Academic Alert system. The purpose of this system is to support communication with students about their progress in courses, especially if there are concerns (e.g., academic difficulty, attendance problems). Entering an academic alert is a great way to supplement open conversations between instructors and students about how students can improve their academic performance and to activate a broader support system. An alert should only be entered after the instructor has reached out to the student directly.

When a faculty member submits an alert that expresses a concern, the student

receives outreach from their academic advisor or the Student Success Specialists in the Office of Academic Advising. Students are no longer receiving automated notification emails when an alert is submitted. It is in the student's best interest to address the alert quickly, as students who do so are more likely to earn credit for the course. Questions about the Academic Alert system can be directed to Anne Marie Roberts (amrober1@unca.edu) in the [Academic Success Center](#).

Late or Missing Assignments

- Reading responses are intended to prepare you for class discussion and should be completed before the associated class meeting. **Late reading responses will not receive credit.** To provide flexibility for illness, busy weeks, and other circumstances, **your two lowest reading-response scores will be dropped.**
- Other assignments submitted within one week of the deadline will receive a 20% late penalty. After one week, late work will not be accepted.
- Some assignments involve presentations, collaborative activities, or other time-sensitive work and may have deadlines that cannot be extended in the same way. Any such expectations will be identified in the assignment instructions.
- Absences or deadlines covered by an approved university accommodation or other applicable university policy will be handled in accordance with that policy.

Use of Technology in the Classroom

Please bring a laptop to every class meeting. We will regularly use class time for in-class activities, research, collaborative work, and exercises that require access to online resources and course materials.

Use of Artificial Intelligence

◇ Use of GenAI in completing course assignments is limited to use with particular assignments and within defined parameters as noted by the instructor, and AI use must be disclosed.

Grievance Procedures for Students

A student grievance procedure exists to serve all enrolled students at UNC Asheville in the event that they judge they have been improperly or unfairly treated in academic matters. Written notice of the grievance must be filed with the Faculty Conciliator, who will attempt to resolve the grievance informally to the satisfaction of all parties. When such informal conciliation proves impossible, students have the right to present their grievance to a closed hearing of the Academic Appeals Board. If a grievance is unfounded the Academic Appeals Board shall provide written notification of that fact to the student, the faculty member, and the departmental Chair. If a grievance is deemed valid, the Board shall forward a written account of its deliberations, including its recommendations for redress, to the student, the faculty member, the department Chair, and the Provost. For further information, see the [Academic Appeals](#) website.

Revisions to Course Information

All materials and assignments in this syllabus are subject to change at the discretion of the professor. Any changes will be clearly communicated by email and updated in the course schedule.

Inclement Weather Policy

In the case of inclement weather, we will follow the policies of the university regarding cancellation, make-up classes, and late start scheduling.

Announcements are delivered through the SafeZone App and will include push notifications, email, text and posts on the UNC Asheville homepage. All students, faculty, and staff are automatically registered. Confirm your contact information at [Bulldog Alert](#).

Decisions are made as early as possible and by 6 a.m. when classes are in session. If a delayed opening is announced, only classes starting at or after that time will meet — for example, an 11 a.m. opening means all classes starting before 11 a.m. are cancelled and all classes at 11 a.m. or later proceed as usual.